FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 10: Pipeline, Follow-Up Cadence, and Activity Math

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 10: Pipeline, Follow-Up Cadence, and Activity Math

How to Use This Guide

This is your last day, and it is the day that keeps everything else alive. Days 1 to 9 gave you a target customer, an opener, a discovery conversation, an offer, a way to present it, a way to handle objections and a way to get paid. Day 10 is about the system that makes those things happen again next week without you guessing.

Work through this guide alone and with your own business in front of you. Keep your notes, your list and your calendar open. Write as you read. Where you see a question, answer it in your own numbers before you move on. The math in this guide is the least glamorous part of selling and the part most founders skip. Skipping it is why founders say selling does not work when what actually failed was tracking.

Everything here is small enough to run in a single working day each week. You do not need software to start. A sheet with columns works. What matters is that every live conversation has a next step and a date, and that you know your own conversion numbers instead of guessing them.

> **NOTES**
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> Do the calculations with real numbers from the last two weeks, even if those numbers are small. Small real numbers beat big imagined ones.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

By the end of this guide you will have a working pipeline, a follow-up rhythm you can keep, and a realistic activity target built from your own data.

- Knowledge: You will know the five numbers that describe your selling week and how each one converts into the next.
- Attitude: You will treat follow-up as part of the sale, not as chasing, and treat your own past data as the only honest source of goals.
- Skill: You will be able to set up a simple pipeline, run a weekly review, and calculate how many outreaches you need to reach your revenue target.
- Upskill: You will design a follow-up cadence that a busy buyer experiences as helpful rather than persistent, and test it on your next ten open conversations.

> **NOTES**
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> Write your revenue target for the next 90 days somewhere you will see it. You will use it in the activity math section.

Why a Pipeline Is a Customer Tool, Not a Chore

A pipeline is a list of conversations with a stage and a next step. That is all. It exists because human memory is a poor filing system for fifteen open conversations, and because a buyer's attention moves slowly and unevenly.

Here is the psychology. Your customer is not thinking about you between conversations. They are running a business, dealing with their own customers, and your offer sits somewhere in the back of their mind with a low priority score attached. That is not rejection; it is normal attention. When you follow up with something relevant, you raise your offer's priority for a moment. When you follow up with nothing relevant, you lower it, and eventually they associate your name with noise.

A pipeline protects you from two costly instincts. The first is the rescue reflex: you feel a quiet conversation slipping, so you push harder, which reads as pressure and pushes the buyer further away. The second is avoidance: you feel unsure of the outcome, so you do not call, and the conversation dies of neglect while you tell yourself they were not interested.

The pipeline replaces both instincts with a date and a reason. Every active conversation has a next contact date and a stated reason for that contact. If you cannot write a reason, the conversation is not ready for a follow-up; it is ready for a decision question.

> **NOTES**
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> If a conversation has no next step, it is not in your pipeline. It is in a list of people you once spoke to.

The Five Numbers That Describe Your Week

Track five numbers every week. They form a chain, and each link tells you where to improve.

Live conversations: how many real two-way conversations you had with a target customer this week. A voicemail is not a conversation. A reply that says "not now" is a conversation.

Conversations that reached a real next step: how many of those conversations ended with a specific next step agreed, whether that is a call, a proposal, a meeting or a trial. This measures the quality of your opener and discovery, not your volume.

Offers or proposals presented: how many conversations progressed to you presenting the offer with A.I.M.

Agreements or purchases: how many customers said yes and committed.

Payments received: how many of those actually paid. Day 9 covered the close; this number tells you whether your payment step is clean.

Set your targets from your own baseline, not from someone else's. If you had six live conversations last week and three reached a next step, your baseline is 50 percent, and your goal for next week is built on that, not on an imagined industry average.

> **NOTES**
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> A single week is noise. Two or three weeks starts to be a pattern. Do not redesign your whole approach after one slow week.

The Weekly Review: Fifteen Minutes

Once a week, sit down for fifteen minutes and answer the same questions. The point is not self-criticism. The point is one small adjustment per week.

Ask yourself, in writing: Did I protect my prospecting time every working day? Which stage did most conversations stop at, and what will I change about that stage? Did every open conversation get a contact this week or a scheduled one? Which past customers are due a check-in next week? Are all opt-out and do-not-contact requests recorded with dates? And finally, what was one moment this week where I drifted into an old habit, and how did I recover?

That last question matters more than it looks. Under pressure, most founders slide back into fast talking, nervous discounting or premature pitching. Naming the drift is how you stop repeating it.

> **NOTES**
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> Put the review in your calendar as a repeating event with a fixed time. A review you have to remember is a review you will skip in a busy week, which is exactly the week you need it.

Follow-Up That Respects the Buyer

Follow-up has a bad reputation because most of it is built around the seller's anxiety rather than the buyer's situation. You can build yours differently.

The rhythm that works for a small business is simple. After a live conversation, send a short written summary the same day: what you heard, what you offered, what happens next, and when. Then follow up at a stated interval, and every follow-up carries something new: an answer to a question they raised, a relevant example, a date that matters, or a clear request for a decision.

Here is the psychology behind it. Each contact either adds information or adds pressure. Buyers experience information as help and pressure as cost, and they remember the cost longer. A follow-up that repeats "just checking in" adds no information and quietly signals that you have nothing new to offer. A follow-up that says "you asked how the onboarding works; here it is in three lines, and here is the decision I need by Thursday to hold the start date" adds information and makes the next step easier.

Respect also means a real ending. If a buyer says they are not interested, thank them and close the loop. If they ask not to be contacted, record it with the date and honor it completely. A clear no is useful data; a reluctant yes is a future problem.

NOTES

Never let a follow-up arrive without a reason the buyer would recognize as being about them. If your reason is that you want an answer, say so plainly and ask for a decision date instead of sending a nudge.

Activity Math: From Outreaches to Customers

This is the calculation that turns hope into a plan. You work backward from your revenue goal to your daily activity.

Step one: count your conversions over the last two weeks. Outreaches to live conversations. Live conversations to offers presented. Offers to agreements. Agreements to payments.

Step two: decide your revenue target and your average sale value, so you know how many customers you need.

Step three: divide backward through your conversion numbers to see how many conversations and outreaches that requires.

Practice example: a founder selling a service at 900 per customer wants 4,500 in new revenue over the next 30 days, so they need 5 customers. Over the last three weeks, 40 outreaches produced 16 live conversations (40 percent), 16 conversations produced 5 offers (about 31 percent), and 5 offers produced 2 agreements (40 percent). To get 5 customers they need about 13 offers, which needs about 41 conversations, which needs about 103 outreaches over the month. Spread across 20 working days, that is about 5 outreaches a day.

Practice example: a B2C founder selling a 60 product needs 50 sales for 3,000. Their history shows 10 sales from 200 conversations, so 50 sales needs about 1,000 conversations, and with 5 outreaches producing 1 conversation, that is 5,000 touches. This is why low-priced products need either volume channels or repeat purchase; the math is not a failure, it is information.

If you have no history yet, do not wait for it. Start with conservative assumed rates, and split them by where the outreach comes from. For warm network or referrals, plan on about 20 to 30 percent of outreaches becoming live conversations. For cold outreach, plan much lower: about 2 to 5 percent. Keep the other two rates modest as well: about 25 percent of conversations producing an offer, and about 40 percent of offers becoming agreements. These are rough starting assumptions, not benchmarks, and they are there to get you moving rather than to predict your future.

Label every one of those numbers as an assumption in your plan. A workable way to start: if you have 30 outreaches a week and a third of them are warm, plan on roughly 3 warm conversations and 1 cold one, not the 9 you would expect if you applied warm rates to all 30. Replace every assumed rate with your real numbers after two weeks of running the system. Until then, your plan is a hypothesis, and you should treat a shortfall as new data rather than a personal failure.

> **NOTES**
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> Use conservative conversion numbers. If your last three weeks ranged from 30 to 45 percent, plan on 30. You can always be pleasantly surprised; you cannot recover a plan built on your best week ever. Write the word assumed next to any rate you have not measured yet, so you know which numbers to swap out first. The warm and cold split matters more than any other assumption: a founder who applies warm-network rates to a cold list builds a plan that fails in the first week and wrongly concludes that selling does not work.

Recording What a Customer Actually Said

Your notes should use the customer's own words, not labels. "Said the new hire starts in three weeks and the current process will not cope" is a note. "Hot lead" is a mood.

For each active contact, record the source of the lead, the next contact date and the reason, and any request not to be contacted, with its date. Do not record assumptions about who the person is beyond what they told you; nothing about their personal circumstances that is not needed to serve them.

This discipline pays off directly in your next conversation. When you open with the customer's own phrase from three weeks ago, they hear that they were listened to, and the trust you built in discovery carries forward.

> **NOTES**
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> Write your notes within an hour of the conversation. After a day, you remember your interpretation, not their words.

Apply It in Your Role

You run your own business, so you are both the seller and the manager of the selling. Set the system up once, then let it run.

Build your pipeline as a sheet with these columns: name, source, what they said they need, stage, last contact, next contact date, next step, opt-out recorded. Sort it by next contact date. Look at it every working morning for two minutes.

Book a fifteen-minute weekly review as a repeating appointment. Do it on the same day each week, ideally a quieter one.

Write your follow-up messages from a template that always contains a new piece of information. Save three versions: one after a first conversation, one after an offer, and one that asks for a decision.

Run the activity math once a month and adjust your daily outreach number. Not daily, not weekly; monthly is enough, because your conversion rates need time to show a pattern.

> **NOTES**
>
> Put the pipeline where you will actually see it. A tracker in a folder you never open is a diary, not a pipeline.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the model answers. Keep your wording natural to you.

- A buyer you spoke to ten days ago has gone quiet. Write the follow-up message, and name the new information you are adding to it.
- A customer says: "I'm not ready yet, I'll come back to you." Decide what you record in your pipeline, what you say, and what date you propose.
- Your weekly review shows that most conversations stopped right after your opener. Name one change you will make next week.
- You have 5 outreaches a day planned but only 3 done by Thursday. What do you do on Friday, and what do you change next week?
- A past customer bought once and you have not contacted them since. Write the check-in message and its reason.

> **NOTES**
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> Aim for the principle, not perfect wording. Your message should sound like you, not like a template.

Key Takeaways

These are the five ideas to carry out of Day 10 and out of this course.

- A pipeline is a list of conversations with a stage, a next step and a date. Nothing more is needed to start.
- Follow-up earns its place by adding information, not by reminding the buyer that you are waiting.
- Five numbers describe your week: conversations, next steps, offers, agreements, payments.
- Set targets from your own baseline. Someone else's conversion rate is not your plan. With no history yet, start from labeled assumptions and replace them with real numbers after two weeks.
- The weekly review is fifteen minutes and one adjustment. Protect it in your calendar.

Quiz

Choose the best answer for each question. Write your answers down before you check them.

1. What makes a conversation part of your pipeline?

   A. You liked the person and want to work with them

   B. It has a stage, a next step and a next contact date

   C. They asked you to send information

   D. They gave you their business card

2. A buyer has gone quiet for two weeks. What makes a follow-up respectful and useful?

   A. Sending it every day until they reply

   B. Explaining again how much you want their business

   C. Adding new, relevant information and a clear decision point

   D. Waiting for them to contact you first

3. You had 50 outreaches, 20 live conversations and 5 offers last month. Roughly how many conversations does one offer take?

   A. About 10

   B. About 4

   C. About 2

   D. About 25

4. Where should your weekly targets come from?

   A. A public industry benchmark

   B. The best week you ever had

   C. Your own recent baseline, planning on the conservative end

   D. Your revenue target divided by twelve

5. What belongs in your notes for an active contact?

   A. A label for how promising they seem

   B. Your assumptions about their personality and budget

   C. The customer's own words, the source, the next contact date and reason, and any opt-out

   D. Only the outcome of your last call

Upskill Challenge

Before you close this course, set up the system in your own business and run it for one full week.

Build the pipeline sheet with the columns from this guide and enter every open conversation you have right now. For each, write a next contact date and a reason. Where you cannot write a reason, decide whether to send a decision question or to close the conversation respectfully.

Run the activity math with your real numbers and write your daily outreach number on a note where you work.

Write your three follow-up templates, each containing a placeholder where new information goes.

Then, at the end of the week, run the fifteen-minute review and answer one extra question: which single change would most improve the stage where most conversations stop? Apply that change in the following week and compare.

☐ Pipeline sheet built with every open conversation entered

☐ A next contact date and a reason against every active contact

☐ Opt-out and do-not-contact requests recorded with dates

☐ Activity math completed with your real numbers and a daily outreach target

☐ Three follow-up templates written, each with a slot for new information

☐ First weekly review completed and one change chosen

> **NOTES**
>
> Do the challenge in a normal working week, not a quiet one. The system has to survive real conditions to be worth keeping.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

A buyer you spoke to ten days ago has gone quiet: "Hi (their name), when we spoke you mentioned the new hire starts in three weeks and the current process will not cope. I have added two short lines below on how the first two weeks would run, and a date question at the end. Would a start on the 14th still work for you, or is later better? If neither fits, tell me and I will close this off for now." Why it works: it opens with their words, adds information they do not have, and gives them an easy way out, so silence is no longer their only safe reply.

"I'm not ready yet, I'll come back to you": record the stage, the reason they gave in their own words, and a next contact date four to six weeks out with a reason attached, for example that their busy season ends then. Say: "Understood. I will not keep nudging you. I will send you one thing in six weeks that is useful whether or not you buy, and you can tell me then where you are." Why it works: it takes the pressure off, which is exactly what makes people come back, and it keeps the door open on their terms rather than yours.

Most conversations stopped right after your opener: one change is to end the opener with a question about their work this week instead of a statement about your offer, then let the silence sit for three seconds. Why it works: the opener earns the next thirty seconds only if it hands the conversation to them, and a statement about you gives them nothing to answer.

5 outreaches a day planned but 3 done by Thursday: on Friday you do the remaining 4 and log 16 for the week instead of 25. Next week you drop the target to 4 a day, in a fixed block, and check whether the block holds before you raise it again. Why it works: a target you miss every week stops being a target, and a rate you can actually sustain tells you the truth about your timeline.

A past customer you have not contacted since: "Hi (their name), your (item) has been running for about six months now, so I wanted to check one thing: is (the common early issue) showing up at

all? Here is a two-minute fix either way." Why it works: it is about their result, not your quota, and it opens the door to a repeat purchase without asking for one.

No history yet: write down your assumed rates, split into warm and cold, mark each one as an assumption, and set a modest daily outreach number from them. Say to yourself: "These are placeholders; in two weeks I replace them with what actually happened." Why it works: a labeled assumption keeps you moving without pretending to certainty, and separating warm from cold stops a cold list from quietly setting you up to fail.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. A stage, a next step and a date are what separate a pipeline from a contact list.
- 2. C. Each contact should add information; a nudge that only reminds them you are waiting adds pressure and nothing else.
- 3. B. Twenty conversations produced five offers, so roughly four conversations per offer.
- 4. C. Your own data is the only honest source, and conservative planning protects you on a slow month.
- 5. C. Their words, the source, the next date and reason, and recorded opt-outs keep your follow-up accurate and respectful.

> **NOTES**
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> Notice that every model answer either adds information or asks a question. If your draft does neither, it is a nudge, not a follow-up. Check your own numbers for one thing: whether the conversation rate you are using came from warm contacts while the list you are about to call is cold. That mismatch is the most common reason a founder's first weekly target collapses.

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